

Blackberry Bold

Black As Usual, But Bolder Than Before

Blackberry is what many would consider the king of smart phones. The large masses might not be impressed by their kind of phones, but these aren't made for those who want to use fancy headphones and play games and movies on them — this doesn't mean you can't. The new Blackberry Bold comes across as one of these kind of phones — the one that is made strictly for the busy manager or businessman but which will let him have some fun at the same time.

The first impression you get is that it's rich and special. The leather-like material back, the shape and of course the glowing tracer ball at the center give you that feeling. The phone is light but a little wide. It's thin at the same time so you shouldn't have any problem fitting it in your pockets. It fits into your palm comfortably as well when you want to use it.

The design of the phone is attractive even though this is supposed to be firstly a practical phone — not something to show off. The only slight problem is with opening the back to access the battery slot. Fortunately that's something you don't have to do very often. The back lit keypad like many other Blackberry devices has a QWERTY design. The keys are bevelled and banked to the sides to make typing easy. It's surprisingly very usable. The key-presses feel right and with some practice, you can get pretty fast with it. The panel between the screen and the QWERTY keypad has the dedicated buttons for picking up, dropping calls and running applications.



The trackball at the center is used to scroll around its beautiful interface. It works well but has a very fine coarseness to it — something like rolling a ball bearing on sandpaper. The body and screen are glossy and that means this phone like many others we've seen recently shows up fingerprints.

The screen is compact because of the phone's size but this is a really good looking screen. It's really dense for its size so images look absolutely amazing. The interface is simple to use and it looks exceptionally good with this kind of screen. There are loads of menus and it's a joy to spend time with each appli-

cation. Applications run very well but the booting time for the phone is considerably slower. Attention is given to every application is great and using them requires no previous experience with Blackberry phones. Applications include some trial versions of Office-replacements. There are time planners and even a few games thrown in for those long waits at the airport. Scrolling through images on the powerful screen is fun and so is watching videos.

A 3.5 mm jack will let you connect your earphones without having to use any pesky converters and adapters. Reception is good but the speaker quality isn't

as impressive. The sides are lined with buttons for volume controls and the slot for attaching external memory cards.

All the usual expected technologies on the checklist can be found on this phone — WiFi, Bluetooth and a 2 MP camera with a flash. Quality is average and using it is not a lot of fun. It shouldn't really matter a lot as this phone isn't design for taking high quality photographs anyway. Speaker quality is decent but it crackles a little bit at high volumes.

If we were to sum it all up right now, then we would say that the Blackberry Bold is impressive but only for the people who need these kind of features. For the younger crowds who want big touchscreens and loud PMP-phones, then there are cheaper options. For the busy individual who needs to be connected all the time, access information and send e-mails, this is one of the best phones to do this. It's fast, accurate and almost glitch-free. The price of Rs 34,990 is expensive but if it's something that makes life simpler for you, then it's worth every single penny.

Specifications

Screen: 480 x 320, 65,000 colours, Built-in GPS, WiFi 802.11a/b/g, Bluetooth, 2 MP camera
Dimensions: 114 x 66 x 15 mm,
Weight: 136 g

Contact: Airtel / Vodafone / Reliance
Web site: www.blackberry.com
Price: Rs 34,990

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Sony Vaio VGN-SR26GN

A Little Less Vaio, Same Old Sony

Sony's SR series mix performance and portability in equal proportions or so they say. The SR26GN's body is done in steel grey with silver which looks suitably suave and business-like while the top of the lid is finished in black embedded with tiny little shiny silver particles; this gives the impression of sheen on the surface which looks tasteful. The screen bezel is quite narrow which is always good and the lid itself is pretty slim; it almost seems as if this laptop uses an LED screen because of its slimmess. Build quality is strictly decent and this is a problem we feel; since Vaio's have always been amazingly well built. There seems to be a noticeable divide in the build quality of the Vaio notebooks below Rs 1 lakh and those above it; we feel this shouldn't be the case as it is a letdown from what we expect from any product wearing the Vaio moniker. With this notebook this build issue is noticeable in the area near the CD tray where there is unnecessary play and flex both in the material and the hollow where the optical drive assembly is inserted.

The trackpad is reasonably sensitive and accuracy is very good; a fingerprint login (read biometrics) device is built into the trackpad between the left and right click buttons. Overall this notebook looks expensive despite the sometimes tacky build and is quite compact for a 13.3-inch; more so than Dells XPS M1330 and Apples Macbook; which speaks volumes for Sony's design.

Well laid out keypad the button spacing on this seg-



regated keypad seems a little wider than that of the keypad on the Macbook/Macbook Pro but we didn't have any serious issue using it. The keys exude a kind of clicky feel in the beginning and the key travel is very short; feedback is positive. There's a dedicated button for switching on your WLAN and Bluetooth but by default it activates the Vaio connection wizard which allows you to choose whether to switch on or off these two connectivity options in addition to LAN and modem options. The power button is an attractive and bright green button that is built into the side of the cylindrical base; the other side of this base accommodates the charging pin. There are also five unmarked buttons on the flap below the screen; and these are configurable; although this isn't very useful as you will probably confuse them because of lack of marking.

The screen itself isn't very good and while super clear and very bright for text and surfing it is a let-

down for any kind of multimedia work because of its poor viewing angles. That being said its viewing angles are only slightly worse than the new Apple Macbook; which is similarly priced. The screen is slightly worse than the LED backlit display of the Dell XPS

M1330. Sony provides a switch called Mode; which toggles between Business, Entertainment and Private modes. These modes are simply customisable screens which can be set up with shortcut icons for common tasks; nifty but pretty useless to most people who may never use it. The icon for each of these modes is present in a small tray at the middle of the bottom part of the screen; this reminds of the Mac systems. Unfortunately there's no one touch restore button which we've come to look for in laptops in this price range and the same is achieved by a certain combination of key presses which is most annoying.

Powered by a new Intel P series processor (P8400, 2.26 GHz) the SR26GN has sufficient horsepower under the hood. 3 GB of RAM makes Vista quite snappy, while an ATI Radeon HD 3470 graphics solution with 256-MB of dedicated memory handles most multimedia tasks (except for gaming) rather easily. We tried gaming and while we were able to get a decent 66 fps in *Company Of Heroes* at a resolution of 1024 x 768 this notebook is

certainly not for gamers. However it will easily get all other tasks done snappily. The presence of an HDMI port is a nice plus; you can hook this up to large screen displays for presentations and such. The notebooks palmrest gets rather warm with usage and we although not hot enough to be of a serious concern it will lightly warm your hands; which may be a good thing or not depending on the weather.

At an MRP of Rs 74,990 the VGN-SR26GN is not a bad laptop. It has a decent screen and is quite compact. It looks classy and will do a businessman proud but then for another Rs 25,000 you can get a Vaio Z series, with a carbon fiber shell and a much better screen that has much better build quality and slightly faster components. Comparing this new Vaio to the new Apple Macbook and the Dell XPS M1330 we have to say that we'd prefer either of those two over this; though not for any serious dearth, just the overall feel of the product. It's got that *built-to-a-budget* feel which we come across in a few products and we personally like to skip them.

Specifications

Core 2 Duo P8400 (2.26 GHz), 3 GB DDR2 667 RAM, 250 GB 5400 rpm HDD, 13.3-inches, Windows Vista Business + Windows XP Prof (downgrade option), weight — 1.96 kg

Contact: Sony India
Phone: 1800-1111-88
Website: www.sony.co.in
Price: Rs 74,990

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★